

Security Sector Accountability, Subnational Security Votes, and Citizen Trust in Post-EndSARS Nigeria: A Senior Research Advisory and Knowledge Evaluation Framework

Analytical Framing of the Post-EndSARS Security Reform Landscape

The historic 2020 EndSARS protests in Nigeria represented a watershed moment in sub-Saharan African governance, highlighting deep-seated patterns of systemic impunity, arbitrary detention, extortion, and physical abuse within the Nigeria Police Force (NPF).¹ Public outrage, primarily led by the youth demographic, forced the disbanding of the notorious Special Anti-Robbery Squad (SARS).¹ This mobilization compelled the Federal Government to introduce legislative reforms, most notably the Nigeria Police Act 2020.⁴

The Police Act 2020 was designed to restructure national security management by integrating constitutional human rights guarantees, institutionalizing community policing, and strengthening oversight via the Police Service Commission (PSC) and the Police Complaints Response Unit (CRU).⁵ Despite these statutory changes, empirical assessments indicate that reform has stalled at the "paper compliance" stage.⁸ This gap is characterized by the formal adoption of progressive legal frameworks without operational integration into daily policing practices.⁸

According to policy audits conducted by civil society organizations, the implementation of the Police Act 2020 is highly inconsistent and fragmented.⁸ The revised Police Regulations, intended to operationalize the Act, were gazetted in December 2025 and formally presented to the Ministry of Police Affairs in February 2026.⁸ However, these regulations have not been systematically distributed to state and divisional police commands, legal practitioners, or the general public.⁸

This regulatory vacuum leaves divisional police officers operating under the obsolete 1968 Regulations, creating an inconsistent legal and operational environment.⁸ Furthermore, statutory compliance remains personality-driven, heavily dependent on the discretion of individual division commanders rather than standardized institutional systems.⁸

This implementation gap is reflected in public opinion. Micro-level survey data from Afrobarometer Round 9 reveal a deep crisis of institutional legitimacy for the NPF.¹¹ Only 15% of adult Nigerians report trusting the police "somewhat" or "a lot," while 73% perceive "most" or

"all" police officers as corrupt—the worst rating among all public institutions surveyed.¹ Furthermore, 77% of citizens describe Nigeria as an unsafe country to live in.¹¹ This sense of insecurity is compounded by negative personal experiences; 62% of citizens report encountering the police in involuntary situations such as checkpoints, identity checks, or traffic stops.¹ Within this group, 55% report having to pay a bribe to avoid problems, and 75% of those who actively sought police assistance report being forced to pay a bribe to obtain help.¹ Consequently, only 13% of Nigerians believe the police operate professionally and respect human rights.¹ This trust deficit has led to a reliance on informal governance mechanisms; 59% of citizens turn first to traditional leaders, informal community courts, or local elders to resolve legal disputes, rather than engaging with formal state law enforcement.¹⁴

Subnational Security Financing and the Political Economy of Discretionary Expenditures

A central element of security sector governance in Nigeria is the subnational allocation of discretionary, off-budget public funds known as "security votes".¹⁵ Originally conceived during military rule as emergency funding instruments to enable state governors to respond rapidly to unforeseen security threats, security votes have evolved into a structural feature of state-level budgeting.¹⁶

These monthly cash allowances run into billions of naira annually and are disbursed entirely at the executive discretion of state governors.¹⁷ They are officially intended to fund sensitive operations, intelligence gathering, and localized crisis management.¹⁹ However, because they are exempt from standard public procurement laws, legislative scrutiny, and external audit, they are widely recognized as a major source of public sector corruption and elite patronage.¹⁵ Audited budgetary data compiled by the BudgIT-backed Open States platform reveal that between 2023 and 2025, Nigerian state governments earmarked a combined ₦525.23 billion for security votes and related subnational operations.¹⁹ This subnational expenditure has risen sharply, climbing from ₦150.47 billion in 2023 to ₦164.07 billion in 2024, and surging to ₦210.68 billion in 2025—a 40.01% increase over the three-year period.¹⁹ This upward trajectory reflects a reactive, crisis-driven fiscal posture among state executives, who face multiple security crises ranging from banditry to secessionist violence.¹⁶

Subnational Security Vote Allocations by State (2023–2025)

The table below presents the cumulative and annual breakdown of disclosed security vote allocations across selected high-spending and low-spending states, illustrating significant subnational variance in fiscal reporting and prioritization.¹⁹

State	2023 Security Vote (₦)	2024 Security Vote (₦)	2025 Security Vote (₦)	Cumulative Disclosed Total (₦)

Borno ¹⁹	8.92 Billion	15.65 Billion	32.83 Billion	57.40 Billion
Anambra ¹⁹	184.90 Million	17.28 Billion	25.10 Billion	42.57 Billion
Delta ¹⁹	17.14 Billion	10.65 Billion	10.65 Billion	38.44 Billion
Benue ¹⁹	9.27 Billion	12.00 Billion	15.60 Billion	36.87 Billion
Ondo ¹⁹	10.11 Billion	10.11 Billion	11.50 Billion	31.72 Billion
Zamfara ¹⁹	7.00 Billion	17.40 Billion	7.00 Billion	31.40 Billion
Edo ¹⁹	6.51 Billion	11.35 Billion	11.35 Billion	29.21 Billion
Adamawa ¹⁹	9.00 Billion	9.00 Billion	9.00 Billion	27.00 Billion
Bauchi ¹⁹	17.39 Billion	12.80 Million	8.00 Billion	25.41 Billion
Kano ¹⁹	2.10 Billion	11.93 Million	5.62 Billion	7.73 Billion
Akwa Ibom ¹⁹	208.00 Million	208.00 Million	208.00 Million	624.00 Million
Rivers ¹⁹	70.00 Million	70.00 Million	70.00 Million	210.00 Million
Ekiti ¹⁹	1.00 Million	1.00 Million	1.10 Million	3.10 Million

This fiscal expansion has occurred alongside a worsening national security crisis.²² Data from the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) Crime Experience and Security Perception Survey show that between May 2023 and April 2024, at least 614,937 Nigerians were killed in violent incidents, while another 2,235,954 were abducted.²² Victims' families paid an estimated ₦2.23 trillion in ransoms to criminal groups during this period.²²

Regionally, the North-West recorded the highest mortality with 206,030 deaths, followed closely by the North-East with 188,992 fatalities.²² The disconnect between rising subnational security expenditures and declining public safety suggests that security votes do not build strategic defense capacity.¹⁶ Instead, they provide discretionary resources that are frequently diverted from long-term capital investments in security infrastructure.¹⁶

This subnational pattern is mirrored at the federal level, where security spending has reached record highs.²³ From 2021 to 2025, the federal government earmarked ₦17.36 trillion for security, with the annual budget peaking at ₦6.85 trillion in 2025—a 39.5% increase over the

previous year.²³

However, as of mid-2025, major security agencies reported massive budget utilization rates alongside high levels of public insecurity.²³ For instance, the Office of the National Security Adviser (ONSA) recorded a capital budget utilization rate of 314.59%, spending ₦228.16 billion against an initial appropriation of ₦72.52 billion.²³ This imbalance suggests a structural misalignment in security sector spending, where resources are concentrated in opaque, short-term contingency channels rather than sustainable institutional reforms.¹⁶

Empirical Mapping of the Citizen Security Trust Index and Mechanical Analogs

To analyze these subnational security dynamics, a multivariate linear regression model was constructed to evaluate the predictors of public trust in law enforcement ⁴:

$$\text{CSTI}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Budget})_i + \beta_2(\text{Incidents})_i + \beta_3(\text{Compliance})_i + e_i$$

Where:

- CSTI_i : The Citizen Security Trust Index for state i , a composite indicator constructed from Afrobarometer Round 9 microdata to measure public confidence in formal security institutions.⁴
- $(\text{Budget})_i$: Per-capita subnational security expenditure across the 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory (FCT).⁴
- $(\text{Incidents})_i$: Security incident density per 100,000 people, derived from geocoded ACLED records spanning 2022 to 2025.⁴
- $(\text{Compliance})_i$: A multi-dimensional compliance score measuring state-level adherence to the Police Act 2020 and its revised regulations.⁴

Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) estimation of this subnational regression model yielded the following parameters ⁴:

$$\text{CSTI}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Budget})_i - 0.312(\text{Incidents})_i + 0.847(\text{Compliance})_i + e_i$$

The empirical findings reveal that statutory compliance is the strongest positive predictor of citizen trust ($\beta_3 = 0.847, p < 0.01$).⁴ Conversely, security incident density exhibits the expected negative association ($\beta_2 = -0.312, p < 0.05$).⁴ Crucially, per-capita

subnational budget allocation fails to significantly predict public trust.⁴ This insignificance suggests that increasing security budgets without establishing functional accountability mechanisms does not improve public confidence.⁴

This model's statistical properties can be understood through an analog in mechanical materials testing, which often encounters similar issues of scale, measurement error, and physical constraints.⁴ When evaluating the load-bearing capacity of polymer-based components under confined compression (such as those used in security transport

equipment), a compressive force of **95 kN** applied to an elastomeric specimen with a cross-sectional area of approximately **2300 mm²** yields an actual compressive stress of ⁴:

$$\sigma = \frac{\text{Force}}{\text{Area}} = \frac{95,000 \text{ N}}{2300 \text{ mm}^2} \approx 41.3 \text{ MPa}$$

If a client reports a compressive stress of **6000 MPa** under these conditions, it represents a significant conversion or measurement error.⁴ Specifically, **41.3 MPa** is equivalent to

approximately **6000 psi** (pounds per square inch).⁴ This discrepancy suggests that the testing software was set to imperial units, or that the operator mistakenly entered a nominal cross-sectional area of **1 mm²** instead of the true specimen area.⁴

Furthermore, polymer specimens under confined compression display non-linear, U-shaped load-bearing behavior across temperature thresholds, mirroring the non-linear relationships often found in social science data.⁴ At room temperature (**23°C**), the polymer exists in a semi-crystalline phase, exhibiting high stiffness and high load capacity.⁴

At **66°C**, the crystalline domains undergo thermal melting, causing the polymer to transition into an amorphous, rubbery state with a sharp drop in structural load capacity.⁴

However, at **93°C**, the specimen exhibits a relative recovery in nominal compressive load due to two factors: entropy elasticity (where the shear modulus of a rubber is proportional to

absolute temperature, $G = Nk_B T$) and triaxial hydrostatic pressure generated by spatial confinement.⁴ Under tight physical confinement, thermal expansion causes the amorphous polymer to press against the rigid chamber walls, artificially inflating the measured nominal load.⁴

Under unconfined uniaxial tensile testing, this U-shaped behavior disappears, resulting in a

monotonic decline in tensile strength (**23°C > 66°C > 93°C**) because the absence of physical boundaries prevents hydrostatic pressure buildup.⁴

Directory of Essential Datasets and Regulatory Documentation

To strengthen this study, several critical datasets and policy documents have been identified. These resources can help refine variables, control for confounders, and establish robust subnational indicators.

Subnational Security Datasets

- **Afrobarometer Round 9 & 10 Nigeria Microdata:**
 - *Repository:* Afrobarometer Data Portal.²⁶
 - *Key Variables:* Individual trust in the police (Q43A), perceived police corruption (Q41H), and experiences with bribery during police interactions (Q44A/B).¹ These variables can be disaggregated by subnational geo-political zones, states, and enumeration areas (EAs).²⁹
- **ACLED Nigeria Subnational Conflict Event Dataset (2020–2026):**
 - *Repository:* Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project.³¹
 - *Key Variables:* Geocoded coordinates of violent events, categorized by actor type (such as state forces, communal militias, or bandit groups) and event type (such as battles, riots, or targeted abductions).²⁷ This allows for the calculation of subnational conflict proximity variables.²⁷
- **BudgIT Open States Subnational Budget Database (2020–2026):**
 - *Repository:* Open States Portal (openstates.ng).¹⁹
 - *Key Variables:* Disaggregated state-level public finance data, enabling the isolation of discretionary "security votes" from formal capital allocations for police infrastructure.¹⁹
- **NBS Crime Experience and Security Perception Survey:**
 - *Repository:* National Bureau of Statistics Elibrary.³⁵
 - *Key Variables:* State-level household victimization rates, kidnapping incidents, and estimated ransom payments.²²

Critical Policy and Regulatory Documents

- **"Beyond Gazetting: The Architecture of Implementation" (April 2026):**
 - *Publisher:* CLEEN Foundation.⁸
 - *Policy Relevance:* Analyzes the structural barriers to the implementation of the Police Act 2020 and provides indicators for state-level compliance.⁸
- **NHRC Annual Reports on Law Enforcement and Human Dignity:**
 - *Publisher:* National Human Rights Commission of Nigeria.³⁷
 - *Policy Relevance:* Tracks subnational violations of human rights, including arbitrary arrests, unlawful detentions, and extrajudicial actions.⁷
- **"Camouflaged Cash: How 'Security Votes' Fuel Corruption in Nigeria":**
 - *Publisher:* Transparency International Defence and Security.¹⁷
 - *Policy Relevance:* Diagnoses how off-budget subnational cash allocations undermine

public financial management and security sector reform.¹⁵

- **"Security Votes and Fiscal Accountability in Nigeria's Security Governance" (March 2026):**
 - *Publisher:* Athena Centre for Policy and Leadership.¹⁶
 - *Policy Relevance:* Establishes a four-pillar framework to reform discretionary security spending, linking allocations to subnational security plans.¹⁶

Methodological Critique and Vulnerability Mitigation

A review of the OLS model reveals three statistical vulnerabilities that should be addressed before peer-reviewed publication.

1. The Ecological Fallacy and Aggregation Bias

The model regresses state-level aggregate variables (NBS budgets and ACLED conflict counts) against an aggregated index of citizen trust (CSTI) derived from individual-level survey responses.⁴ Regressing state-level averages on individual characteristics risks committing an ecological fallacy.⁴⁰

The relationships observed at the state level (such as states with higher compliance exhibiting higher average trust) may not hold for individual citizens within those states.⁴⁰ For example, a state may exhibit high overall compliance with the Police Act 2020, but low-income, marginalized, or rural citizens within that state may still face police extortion and distrust.¹⁴

To address this, the study should transition from an Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) macro-regression to a Multilevel Mixed-Effects Model (Hierarchical Linear Modeling).⁴² This

framework nests individual-level survey respondents (ij) within their respective subnational states (j), allowing for the simultaneous estimation of individual-level predictors (such as lived poverty and urban-rural status) and state-level predictors (such as security votes and compliance)⁴³:

$$\text{Trust}_{ij} = \gamma_{00} + \gamma_{10}(\text{Poverty})_{ij} + \gamma_{01}(\text{Compliance})_j + u_{0j} + r_{ij}$$

2. Sample Size Limitations and Statistical Power

Operating at the state level yields an effective sample size of $N = 37$ (36 states plus the FCT).⁴ Running a multiple linear regression with three independent variables on only 37 observations limits statistical power, increases standard errors, and inflates the risk of overfitting.³⁰ Under these conditions, the high coefficient for statutory compliance ($\beta_3 = 0.847$) is likely inflated by subnational outliers or endogeneity.⁴

Transitioning to a multilevel model addresses this by leveraging the full individual-level sample

of the Afrobarometer survey ($N \approx 1,600$), using the 37 states as group-level clustering units.²⁹

3. Omitted Variable Bias and Endogeneity

The model does not control for several key confounding variables:

- **Media Exposure:** Media coverage of police brutality significantly erodes public trust, independent of actual local incident rates.¹²
- **The "Moulton" Clustering Problem:** Because the treatment variables (Budget and Compliance) are measured at the state level, failing to adjust for intra-state correlation in the covariance matrix will result in downward-biased standard errors, overstating the precision of state-level effects.⁴²
- **Endogeneity of Compliance:** It is possible that states with pre-existing institutional capacity and higher public trust find it easier to implement the Police Act 2020, reversing the assumed direction of causality.⁴

Viva Voce and Mock Oral Examination Suite

This section presents a mock oral defense and interview framework designed to test the researcher's mastery of their thesis.

Question 1: Operationalizing Compliance and Construct Validity

Interviewer: "You identify statutory compliance as the strongest positive predictor of citizen trust ($\beta_3 = 0.847$).⁴ However, the CLEEN Foundation's policy brief 'Beyond Gazetting' states that the implementation of the Police Act 2020 has stalled at the paper compliance stage, characterized by regulatory fragmentation and personality-driven execution at divisional levels.⁸ If compliance is highly inconsistent and largely 'void' at local levels, how did you operationalize and measure your Compliance variable across states? What objective indicators did you use to prevent your model from measuring the subjective perceptions of the respondents?"

Candidate: "This question goes to the construct validity of the $(\text{Compliance})_i$ variable.⁴ To prevent endogeneity and subjective perception bias, this study did not rely on self-reported citizen perceptions of police compliance from the Afrobarometer survey. Doing so would introduce circular reasoning, as trust would be regressed on variables that are themselves components of trust.⁴

Instead, $(\text{Compliance})_i$ was operationalized as an objective, multi-dimensional index constructed from external, administrative data sources. Drawing on the CLEEN Foundation's annual Police Reform Audit and National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) state-level reports, states were scored on five concrete indicators⁸:

1. **Oversight Infrastructure:** The formal establishment and active funding of state-level Police Public Complaints Response Units (PPCRUs).⁴⁹
2. **Procedural Compliance:** The percentage of police divisions within a state utilizing

mandatory, standardized arrest/detention registers as required by Section 74 of the Act.⁶

3. **Judicial Accountability:** The number of state-level judicial panels of inquiry established post-EndSARS that successfully completed hearings and disbursed victim compensation funds.⁵⁰
4. **Local Structural Implementation:** The percentage of local government areas (LGAs) within the state that have functional, statutorily recognized Community Policing Committees (CPCs).⁶
5. **Oversight Activation:** The frequency of mandatory monthly inspection visits conducted by chief magistrates to local police stations under Section 70 of the Act.⁵

By using this objective index, the model isolates structural, administrative compliance from individual perceptions of trust, thereby validating the finding that actual institutional adherence to reform significantly drives public confidence.^{4**}

Evaluation Metrics: The candidate must clearly differentiate between subjective perceptual indices (from surveys) and objective administrative metrics (from institutional audits) to demonstrate construct validity. They should cite specific sections of the Police Act 2020 (such as Section 70 or 74) to support their response.⁵

Question 2: Resolving the Subnational Sampling and Disaggregation Dilemma

Interviewer: "Your model aggregates individual-level trust data from the Afrobarometer survey to the state level, yielding an N of only 37.⁴ Methodologically, this design is vulnerable to the ecological fallacy.⁴⁰ Furthermore, Afrobarometer's sampling frame is designed to be nationally representative, with standard samples of $N = 1,200$ or $N = 2,400$ yielding a $\pm 2.5\%$ margin of error at the national level.³⁰ When you disaggregate this data down to the 36 individual states, your sample size per state drops to roughly 40 to 45 respondents. How do you defend your statistical findings against the critique that your state-level trust aggregates are highly unstable, prone to extreme sampling error, and that your OLS regression is underpowered?"

Candidate: "The limitation regarding subnational sample size and the risk of ecological fallacy are valid critiques that represent the core econometric challenges of subnational research in developing contexts.⁴⁰

First, regarding the instability of the state-level aggregate trust measure: while it is true that the standard Afrobarometer Round 9 sample for Nigeria ($N = 1,600$, executed by NOIPolls) is optimized for national-level representation, the survey design utilizes a stratified, multi-stage area probability sample stratified by the 36 states and the FCT.²⁹ However, to address the high sampling variance inherent in state-level aggregates with small cell sizes ($n \approx 44$ per state), this study implemented two econometric corrections:

1. **Weighted Aggregation:** All state-level trust indices were computed using Afrobarometer's within-country sample weights to correct for unequal selection

probabilities across rural-urban strata and clusters.²⁹

2. **Robust Standard Errors & Bootstrap Resampling:** To address the issues of a small sample size ($N = 37$) and potential non-normality of the error term, standard errors were estimated using 5,000 bootstrap replications. This non-parametric approach does not rely on asymptotic distribution assumptions, ensuring that the significance of statutory compliance ($p < 0.01$) and incident density ($p < 0.05$) remains robust even with 37 observations.⁴

Second, to address the ecological fallacy, this research is currently being expanded into a Multilevel Mixed-Effects Model.⁴² In this HLM framework, the dependent variable—individual trust in the police—is kept at Level 1 (the individual level, $N = 1,600$).³⁰ The independent variables of Budget, Incident Density, and Compliance are modeled as Level 2 (state-level) predictors.⁴ Standard errors are clustered at the state level to account for the Moulton problem, which prevents the overestimation of the statistical significance of state-level policies on individual behavior.⁴² This transition resolves the ecological fallacy while preserving the theoretical integrity of the cross-state analysis.^{40**}

Evaluation Metrics: The candidate must demonstrate a clear understanding of survey weighting, stratification, bootstrap resampling, and the theoretical structure of Hierarchical Linear Modeling (HLM) as a solution to aggregation bias and the Moulton clustering problem.³⁰

Question 3: The State Policing Debate and Subnational Fiscal Policy

Interviewer: "Your model indicates that subnational per-capita budget allocations do not

significantly predict citizen trust (β_1 is insignificant).⁴ From a policy perspective, this suggests that increasing security funding without reforming accountability mechanisms is futile.⁴ Concurrently, there is an active national debate in Nigeria regarding the establishment of State Police forces, with 72% of citizens expressing support for decentralization.⁵⁴ Opponents argue that state governors will weaponize state police forces for regime security, using their discretionary 'security votes' (which totaled over ₦525 billion) as unaccountable political slush funds.⁸ How do your empirical findings inform this policy debate? Should Nigeria move forward with State Police, and if so, how does your model suggest we structure its fiscal and operational oversight to prevent a localized replication of the SARS crisis?"

Candidate: "The empirical insignificance of per-capita security expenditure on public trust (β_1) provides critical, data-driven leverage in the State Police debate.⁴ It proves that the primary constraint to effective democratic policing in Nigeria is not resource scarcity, but rather an implementation deficit rooted in weak accountability.⁹

The model's findings warn against the decentralized creation of state police forces under the current subnational fiscal framework.¹⁰ If states are allowed to establish police forces while financing them through opaque, discretionary 'security votes' that operate outside standard public financial management systems, we will see a rapid localization of impunity and regime

protection.⁸ This is supported by our finding that statutory compliance—not budget size—is the sole determinant of citizen trust.⁴

Therefore, these findings suggest a three-track policy conditionality for the implementation of State Police:

1. **Fiscal Reclassification and the Abolition of Opaque Security Votes:** State policing must not be funded via discretionary executive envelopes.¹⁶ All security expenditures must be transitioned to transparent, line-item legislative appropriations subject to independent, confidential audits by State Auditors-General, balancing operational secrecy with fiscal accountability.¹⁶
2. **National Standardization and Joint Oversight:** To prevent state police forces from being weaponized by governors, operational standards, recruitment criteria, and disciplinary actions must remain under a unified, independent federal-state oversight architecture, such as a reformed National Police Service Commission (PSC) and the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC).⁶
3. **Statutory Integration of Community-Led Accountability:** State police legislation must mandate the creation of local, civilian-led Community Policing Committees (CPCs) with co-management authority over local security plans, ensuring that the police are accountable to the communities they serve rather than to state executives.^{6**}

Evaluation Metrics: The candidate must link their empirical findings (β_1 and β_3) to current policy realities.⁴ They should explain how subnational discretionary spending (security votes) interacts with institutional design, and propose specific fiscal and oversight reforms supported by policy documentation.¹⁶

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